

Open your eyes and see the clear picture as we test the best CRTs and LCDs in the market in search of that perfect display

The fastest processor that money can buy, plenty of hard disk space, and oodles of RAM—most people have these at the top of their shopping list when chalking up a dream machine for themselves. However, one important aspect of PC performance often gets completely overlooked, and that is the display.

This should ideally be one of the more important things for any computer user to consider. First, because the display, which depends both on the monitor and the graphics card, is one of the more expensive components that you will buy—it makes up about a quarter of the cost of your entire system. The monitor in

particular is a long-term investment, a good monitor can give you trouble-free performance for years.

A second and equally important consideration is that newer software demands more and more from the display subsystem of computers. For example, there is no way that the 2 MB graphics card and 14-inch monitor that were the norm just three years ago, can do justice to the modern GUIs for operating systems such as Windows XP, Mac OS X, and Helix Gnome.

But sadly the monitor, is still taken for granted by most users. New PC buyers usually just take whatever their vendor offers them. At best, a little thought is given to the size of the monitor.

Today we have a wealth of choices available to us at reasonable cost. You can easily buy a 17-inch CRT monitor for less than Rs 10,000 and you will occasionally come across a gigantic 21-inch CRT unit for less than Rs 50,000.

The prices of LCD displays have also come down over the last year making them an attractive proposition. With their sleek looks, compact size and lower radiation levels, they will only rise in popularity as time goes by.

However, choosing a monitor suited to your needs is not simple. You need to strike a balance between picture quality and the amount of money you're willing to spend on buying a monitor. We help you make the right choice.

CRT MONITORS

The CRT monitor continues to remain the display of choice in India. We received 13 different brands of CRT monitors in this comparison test, making this a hotly contested territory. The influx of brands in the market place has led to a significant drop in prices over the last year.

One important trend that was reflected in the kind of monitors we received for testing was that the 15-inch monitors seem to have become less popular. While in previous years this category would see the largest number of contestants it has now been superseded by the 17-inch category in terms of popularity. This can be attributed to the fact that this category has seen a significant price drop.

At the same time there's been a remarkable price reduction in 15-inch monitors too. A year ago you would get a 15-inch monitor for around Rs 8,000, whereas now you can get one for Rs 5,400. Prices have fallen in the 19-inch category as well. Could you have ever imagined buying a 19-inch monitor for under Rs 20,000? Well you can now buy one for as low as Rs 17,000!

All this variety has made choosing the right monitor an even more challenging

task. We had a close look at 44 different models to find you some of the best deals that are available today.

Geometry test

Most people who use their computer for general office applications will not notice minor irregularities in screen geometry. But if you need to work with CAD/CAM applications, engineering drawings or with professional 3D content, where accurate geometric shapes need to be generated, then it's crucial that your monitor's screen regulation be impeccable.

Another factor that's important is the ability of the monitor to generate consistent images when the intensity of light changes suddenly. If the images flicker or get distorted with sudden changes in



The screen in Geometry test1



Viewsonic E53 (15-inch monitor)

brightness levels, for instance when watching a movie or a Flash presentation, it can lead to an eye strain.

All 11 of the 15-inch monitors showed a clear pattern, but the scores in the Geometry test were a trifle low because all the 15-inch monitors we received were 'non-flat' tubes—since CRTs are not perfectly spherical, the focus on the screen will not be uniform. However, the electronics in the monitor compensate for some of this variance.

A score of around 10 points should be